THE LOWER MINNESOTA RIVER VALLEY · FIFTY YEARS, 1976–2026

Minnesota Valley
National Wildlife Refuge

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FORT SNELLING TO HENDERSON · MNI SOTA WAKPA

Established by Congress on October 8, 1976, Minnesota Valley National Wildlife Refuge is part of a corridor of land and water stretching nearly 70 miles along the Minnesota River (Mni Sota Wakpa), from Bloomington to Henderson. Its more than 15,000 acres of marsh, floodplain lake, bottomland forest, oak savanna and prairie give migrating waterfowl, bald eagles and songbirds a haven at the edge of the Twin Cities. The valley is Dakota homeland; Bdote, where the Minnesota and Mississippi rivers meet, is a place of deep significance to the Dakota Oyate.

MINNEAPOLIS
SAINT PAUL
WEST ST. PAUL
SOUTH ST. PAUL
EDINA
RICHFIELD
MENDOTA
MENDOTA HEIGHTS
INVER GROVE HEIGHTS
EAGAN
BLOOMINGTON
EDEN PRAIRIE
CHANHASSEN
VICTORIA
WACONIA
CHASKA
CARVER
COLOGNE
NORWOOD YOUNG AMERICA
PLATO
HAMBURG
GREEN ISLE
ARLINGTON
SHAKOPEE
SAVAGE
BURNSVILLE
APPLE VALLEY
ROSEMOUNT
PRIOR LAKE
LAKEVILLE
CREDIT RIVER
FARMINGTON
EMPIRE
COATES
JORDAN
BELLE PLAINE
HENDERSON
NEW PRAGUE
HENNEPIN COUNTY
CARVER COUNTY
McLEOD COUNTY
SIBLEY COUNTY
SCOTT COUNTY
DAKOTA COUNTY
LE SUEUR COUNTY
LONG MEADOW LAKE UNIT
BLACK DOG LAKE UNIT
BLOOMINGTON FERRY UNIT
WILKIE UNIT
UPGRALA UNIT
CHASKA UNIT
RAPIDS LAKE UNIT
LOUISVILLE SWAMP UNIT
SAN FRANCISCO UNIT
ST. LAWRENCE UNIT
JESSENLAND UNIT
BLAKELEY UNIT
Minnesota River
Mni Sota Wakpa
Mississippi River
Wakpa Tanka
Bdote
where two waters come together
Historic Fort Snelling
Pike Island
Sibley Historic Site
Oheyawahi (Pilot Knob)
Minneapolis–St. Paul International Airport
Fort Snelling National Cemetery
Snelling Lake
Big Rivers Trail
Bloomington Education and Visitor Center
Gun Club Lake
Mall of America
Bass Ponds
Long Meadow Lake
Fort Snelling State Park
Old Cedar Ave.
Jens Caspersen Landing
Minnesota River Greenway
Black Dog Lake
Lyndale Ave.
River Bottoms Trail
Nine Mile Creek
Fleming Field
Moores Lake
Pine Bend Bluffs SNA
Baldwin Lake
Spring Lake
Lebanon Hills Regional Park
Minnesota Zoo
Savage Fen Scientific and Natural Area
Murphy-Hanrehan Park Reserve
Crystal Lake
Orchard Lake
Marion Lake
Whitetail Woods Regional Park
Vermillion Highlands Research, Recreation and WMA
Vermillion River
Credit River
Bloomington Ferry
Fisher Lake
Rice Lake
Wilkie
Blue Lake
Valleyfair
The Landing
Canterbury Park
Grass Lake
Flying Cloud Airport
Purgatory Creek
Riley Creek
Eagle Creek
Seminary Fen SNA
Minnesota Valley State Recreation Area
Little Rapids historical marker
Carver Creek
Renaissance Festival
Louisville Swamp
Jabs Farm
North Hunter Lot
Rapids Lake
Carver Rapids
Rapids Lake Education and Visitor Center
Sand Creek
Bevens Creek
Minnesota Valley State Trail
Minnesota Valley State Recreation Area
Shakopee Mdewakanton Sioux Community
Mystic Lake Casino
O'Dowd Lake
Deans Lake
Lower Prior Lake
Upper Prior Lake
Spring Lake
Spring Lake Regional Park
Cleary Lake
Cleary Lake Regional Park
Geis Lake
Fish Lake
Pleasant Lake
Cedar Lake
Cedar Lake Farm Regional Park
Graham Lake
Clark Lake
Ney WMA
Ney Nature Center
Robert Creek
High Island Creek
Hyland-Bush-Anderson Lakes Park Reserve
Bush Lake
Bryant Lake
Staring Lake
Lake Riley
Lotus Lake
Christmas Lake
Lake Minnetonka
Lake Minnewashta Regional Park
Lake Minnewashta
Lake Zumbra
Carver Park Reserve
Parley Lake
Lake Auburn
Stieger Lake
Minnesota Landscape Arboretum
Wassermann Lake
Piersons Lake
Lake Bavaria
Hazeltine Lake
Lake Waconia
Rice Lake
Miller Lake
Tiger Lake
Barnes Lake
Maria Lake
Curran Lake
Erin Lake
Washington Lake
Schauer Lake
Silver Lake
494
35W
35E
35
694
100
62
77
110
55
52
3
149
56
13
169
101
41
212
5
7
284
25
282
21
19
50
10
CANADA
N.D.
MINNESOTA
S.D.
IOWA
WIS.
MICH.
ARDEN HILLS ARMY TRAINING SITE
Round Lake
ROUND LAKE UNIT

REFUGE UNITS

	acres
Long Meadow Lake *Bloomington*	2,403
Black Dog Lake *Burnsville*	1,500
Bloomington Ferry *Bloomington*	437
Wilkie *Shakopee, Savage*	2,037
Upgrala *Eden Prairie, Chanhassen*	419
Chaska *Carver, Chaska*	580
Rapids Lake *Carver*	2,203
Louisville Swamp *Jordan, Shakopee*	2,625
San Francisco *Jordan, Carver*	52
St. Lawrence *Jordan, Belle Plaine*	451
Jessenland *Belle Plaine, Henderson*	1,127
Blakeley *Henderson*	1,144
Round Lake *Arden Hills (inset)*	157
Total	**15,135**

Includes fee-title, easement and cooperatively managed lands; acreages computed from USFWS unit data.

VISITOR CENTERS

Bloomington Education and Visitor Center
3815 American Blvd. East, Bloomington · 952-854-5900

Rapids Lake Education and Visitor Center
15865 Rapids Lake Road, Carver · 952-361-4500

www.fws.gov/refuge/minnesota-valley

LOCATION

ROUND LAKE UNIT, ARDEN HILLS

About 13 miles north of Historic Fort Snelling · scale 1:21,000

LEGEND

- 🟩 Refuge land owned by USFWS (fee title)
- 🟩 Refuge easement or cooperative agreement
- Approved refuge acquisition boundary
- Valley floor, up to about 30 ft above the river
- River or lake
- Marsh or swamp
- Stream
- State park or recreation area
- Scientific and Natural Area or Wildlife Mgmt. Area
- Regional or county park
- Tribal land
- Airport grounds
- County boundary
- Refuge trail
- State trail
- Regional trail
- Interstate
- U.S. or state freeway
- U.S. or state highway
- County road
- Local road
- Railroad
- Visitor center
- Trailhead or parking
- Boat launch
- ▲ Historic site
- ● Point of interest
- Airport
- ○ City or town under 5,000 people
- 35W 169 13 Interstate, U.S. and state routes

Scale 1:42,000 at 84 × 42 in · 1 inch = about 0.66 mile (use the bars at other sizes)

0 1 2 3 4 5 miles

0 2 4 6 8 kilometers

N

Shaded relief from USGS 3DEP 10-meter elevation. The north arrow points to grid north, within 1 degree of true north on this map. UTM projection, zone 15 north, North American Datum of 1983.

Data sources. U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service: refuge units and land status, approved acquisition boundary, trails and facilities (FWS cadastral and refuge facilities data, 2020–2026); unit acreages are computed from these data. U.S. Geological Survey: 3D Elevation Program 1/3 arc-second elevation (relief shading and valley-floor tint), National Hydrography Dataset, Geographic Names Information System. U.S. Census Bureau: TIGER/Line Shapefiles 2025 (roads, rail, boundaries, cities, tribal lands, river surfaces), 2025 cartographic boundary files, Vintage 2025 population estimates. Minnesota Department of Natural Resources via the Minnesota Geospatial Commons: state parks, Scientific and Natural Areas, Wildlife Management Areas, state trails, lakes and wetlands. Metropolitan Council: regional parks, regional trails, airport boundaries. Minnesota Department of Transportation: airport runways. Dakota place names (Bdote, Mni Sota Wakpa, Wakpa Tanka, Oheyawahi): Minnesota Historical Society and National Park Service.

Boundaries are approximate and for general reference only. This is not an official U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service publication; check with the refuge for current regulations, trail conditions and seasonal closures. Map compiled October 2026.

FIFTY YEARS ON THE RIVER · 1976–2026

1976
Congress establishes the refuge on October 8 (Public Law 94-466), authorizing an initial purchase of 9,500 acres.

1984
A conservation plan is completed with the State of Minnesota and local partners; the Act is amended to add 2,000 acres.

1995
The Mittelstad tract, today's Rapids Lake Unit, is added, bringing the refuge to nearly 14,000 acres.

2020
The refuge is designated an urban wildlife refuge and awarded $1 million to strengthen urban programs.

2026
The refuge marks 50 years with anniversary events. More than 45 miles of free trails are open daily, 5 a.m. to 10 p.m.